

Fasting could regenerate your immune system, study

Refraining from food as little as two days can regenerate the immune system, helping the body to fight infections, according to a new study.

Scientists at the new University of Southern California said the findings have a major implication for elderly and people suffering from damaged immune system, such as cancer patients. Researchers tested the effects of fasting for two to four-day periods over the course of six months on both mice and humans. In both cases, long periods of not eating significantly lowered cell counts.

“And the good news is that the body got rid of the parts of the system that might be damaged or old, the inefficient parts, during the fasting.” He added, “Now, if you start with a system heavily damaged by chemotherapy or using fasting cycles can generate, literally, a new immune system.”

The study also found that fasting reduces levels of the enzyme PKA, an effect which is known to increase longevity in simple organisms, as well as levels of the hormone IGF-I, which is known linked to aging, tumor progression and cancer risk, in addition, a small pilot clinical trial found

that fasting for a 72- hour period to chemotherapy protected patients against toxicity.

“While chemotherapy takes lives, it causes significant collateral damage to the immune system. The results of this study suggest that fasting may mitigate some of the harmful effects of chemotherapy” said Tanya Dwarf, assistant Professor of clinical medicine at the University of Southern California.

More clinical studies are needed, and any such dietary intervention should be undertaken only under the guidance of a physician.

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